

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

On Head & Shoulders

How women and Gen Z consumers perceive the stigma associated with dandruff, and their trust in Head & Shoulders..

INSIGHT

- Gen Z first encounters dandruff in their teen years, using mother-chosen products — making H&S a default family brand, not a personal choice.
- As they gain autonomy, especially females, they shift to more aesthetic and premium shampoos.
- Sufferers see dandruff as normal; non-sufferers think it signals poor hygiene, keeping stigma alive.
- Flakes cause embarrassment, but using anti-dandruff shampoo does not.
- People notice dandruff mainly on their own gender, and many think it's more common in men.
- H&S is viewed as masculine and clinical, lacking beauty appeal for women.
- Gen Z is curious but slow to switch — trial sizes are critical.

IMPLICATION

- Branding Communication:
 - Shift from "anti-dandruff" to confidence-led scalp care.
 - Use gender-specific communication.
 - Make scalp science simple and relatable.
 - Build a stronger beauty + confidence brand story.
- Create a beauty-forward female line.
- Expand minis, sachets, and salon trials to ease switching.



BACKGROUND

MARKET CONTEXT GROWTH OF HAIR & SCALP CARE + ANTI-DANDRUFF

Hair & Scalp Care Market

- Global market ≈ \$104B (2024) → projected \$196B by 2034 (~6.5% CAGR).
- Shampoo remains the largest segment due to steady everyday use.
- Growth driven by rising interest in scalp health, irritation concerns, and preventive care.

Anti-Dandruff Segment

- Anti-dandruff makes up ~38% of scalp-care globally.
- Category valued at ~\$10.7B (2025) → ~\$18B by 2035.
- Consumer demand rising for gentle, effective, and scalp-wellness solutions.

Regional & Distribution Trends

- Asia-Pacific leads (~40% share), driven by population and grooming culture.
- Strong momentum in China & India due to climate and lifestyle.
- Retail expanding beyond supermarkets to e-commerce, salons, drugstores, enabling premium growth.

Head & Shoulders

- Category is large and growing — but evolving.
- Consumers want premium, gentle, and beauty-aligned scalp solutions.
- H&S must modernize beyond “classic anti-dandruff shampoo” to stay competitive.

BACKGROUND

COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE

established players + niche challengers

- Globally, H&S leads the anti-dandruff category with a ~10.2% market value share (2025).
- Other major players and competitors include brands such as Dove, Neutrogena (T/Gel), Selsun Blue, Nizoral, and regional / natural brands, many positioning themselves on natural/herbal ingredients, scalp-safe formulations, sulfate-free cleansers, and premium sensorial appeal.
- Shampoo/herbal-based and scalp-health oriented lines (especially those with moisturizing, scalp-soothing, or natural ingredient claims) are growing in popularity.

TREND DRIVERS

- Scalp “skinification” movement
- Premiumization & aesthetic demand
- Growth of natural / gentle formulations
- Rise of multi-channel retail & e-commerce

Head & Shoulders

- H&S needs to evolve beyond “basic anti-dandruff shampoo” to stay competitive: by offering premium-feel, scalp-health-first, beauty-aligned products.
- Given fragmentation and rising demand for differentiated offerings, there's clear space for a repositioned H&S that marries efficacy, scalp health, and modern aesthetics.
- Multi-channel distribution (e-commerce, salons, specialty stores) is essential to reach emerging consumer segments (Gen Z, scalp-conscious buyers, premium seekers).

BUSINESS CHALLENGE

Because scalp care is a high-growth, strategically important category, Head & Shoulders holds a strong leadership position in the anti-dandruff space. However, the combination of stigma, ingredient suspicion, and evolving consumer expectations around gentleness and beauty creates a tension. If H&S cannot reassure consumers, especially women and younger cohorts, on trust and identity, it risks losing share to “clean” or gentler competitors or failing to recruit emotionally engaged users.

BRAND PERSPECTIVE (ETIC)

Head & Shoulders leads in anti-dandruff performance, but negative perceptions of harshness or safety, alongside an image that skews clinical/“medicated,” pose real threats. Its growth could stall if consumers defect to gentler or more “beauty-forward” alternatives.

CONSUMER PERSPECTIVE (EMIC)

Consumers want effective scalp care that feels safe, gentle, and beauty-aligned. They may feel conflicted: embarrassed to need anti-dandruff solutions yet skeptical about manufacturer claims

METHODOLOGY / SAMPLE DETAILS

SURVEY

- **Reason:** Size the problem and understand what moves consideration
- **Method:** 10-minute online survey
- **Sample size:** n = 50 (in the US)
 - Location: in the US
 - Age: 18–24 (Gen Z focus)
- **Recruit:** Social media posts on personal accounts, Relevant Facebook groups, Reddit communities

44 survey responses

INTERVIEW

- **Reason:** We need consumers' own words and lived context around stigma and beauty expectations.
- **Method:** 30-minute, 1:1 semi-structured video interviews (Zoom).
- **Sample size:** 8 people
 - Location: in the US
 - Age: 18–24 (Gen Z focus)
 - Gender: 5 women / 3 men (female focus, but include male contrast).
 - Experience: 5 dandruff sufferers / 3 non-sufferers (include outsiders' perception)
- **Recruit:** Follow-up invitations through a survey question asking participants to provide their email if they were willing to be interviewed, Social media outreach through personal accounts, Word of mouth, including referrals from friends

Eight 30-min 1-1 Interviews

HAIR CARE IS PRIMARILY **BEAUTY-FOCUSED** FOR GEN Z FEMALES AND **UTILITY-FOCUSED** FOR MALES.

FEMALE

FEMALES HAVE MORE COMPLEX BEAUTY-DRIVEN ROUTINES (CONDITIONERS, OILS, HEAT CARE).

“Hair is tough and needs hydrating formulas.”

“Curly hair gets frizzy without extra care.”

MALE

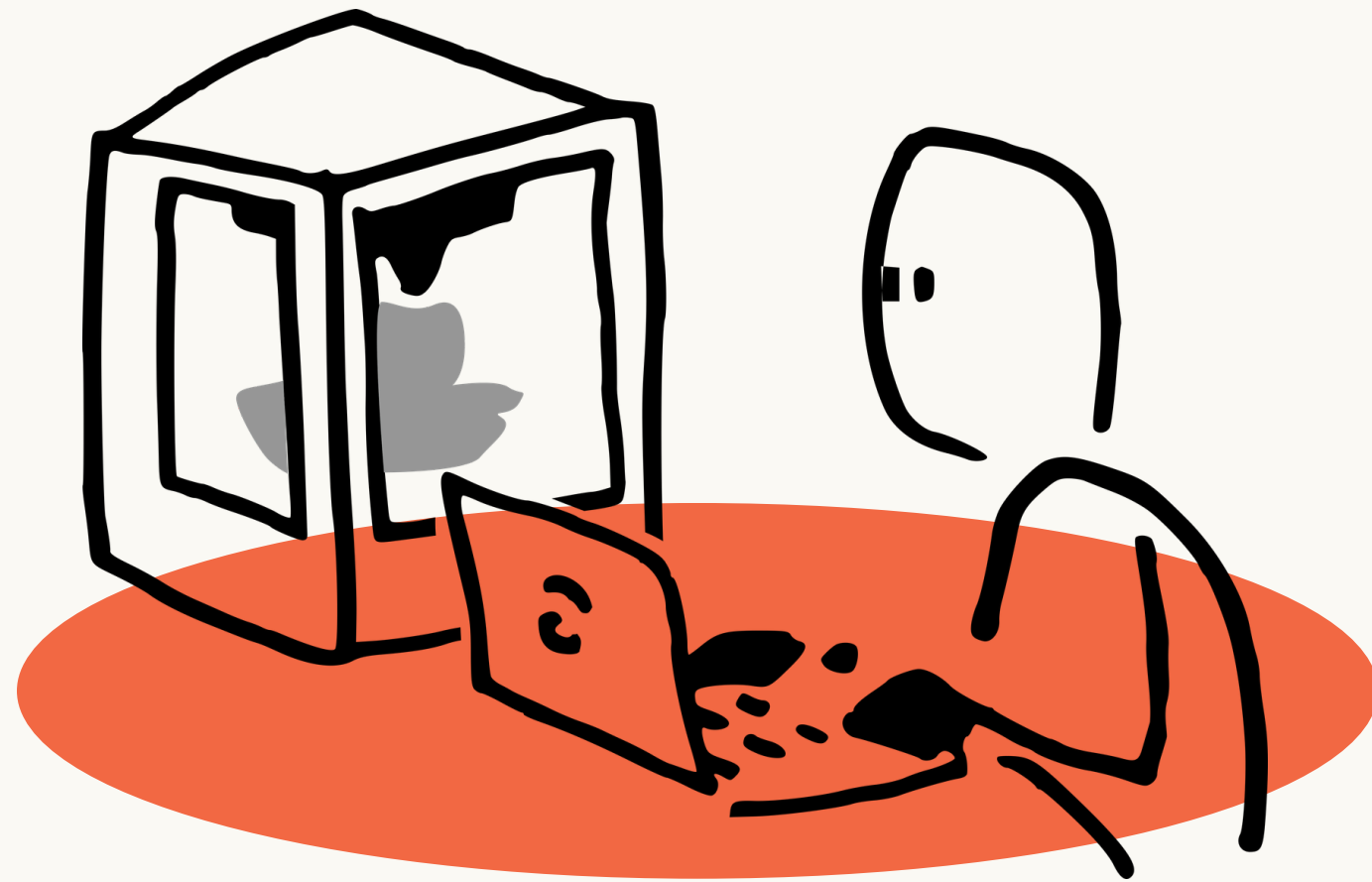
MALES HAVE MINIMAL ROUTINES AND LOWER INVOLVEMENT.

“Shampoo is shampoo. I use whatever I get for free.”

“Routine is simple: wash hair, no extra steps.”

MOST CONSUMERS MISATTRIBUTE THE ROOT CAUSE OF DANDRUFF

People commonly believe dandruff is caused by **external or lifestyle factors**, dead skin, oily scalp, weather, age, or poor hygiene. Only a few spontaneously recognize the **real cause (fungus)**, while others combine half-accurate explanations or misconceptions.



"Dandruff was caused by dry skin accumulating and falling onto clothes."

"The cause was oily scalp and sweat buildup, combined with styling products"

"I feel like it's a fungal infection... I'm not sure... something about your scalp gets off balance."

Consumers treat dandruff as a surface problem, not a biological one. This makes anti-dandruff intervention feel **optional** unless flakes are visible.

SUFFERERS **NORMALIZE** DANDRUFF; NON-SUFFERERS ASSOCIATE IT WITH **POOR HYGIENE**



People who have experienced dandruff view it as a common, manageable issue. Non-sufferers often assume it signals poor hygiene because they rarely notice flakes on others.

"Others with dandruff aren't doing their hygiene... correctly."

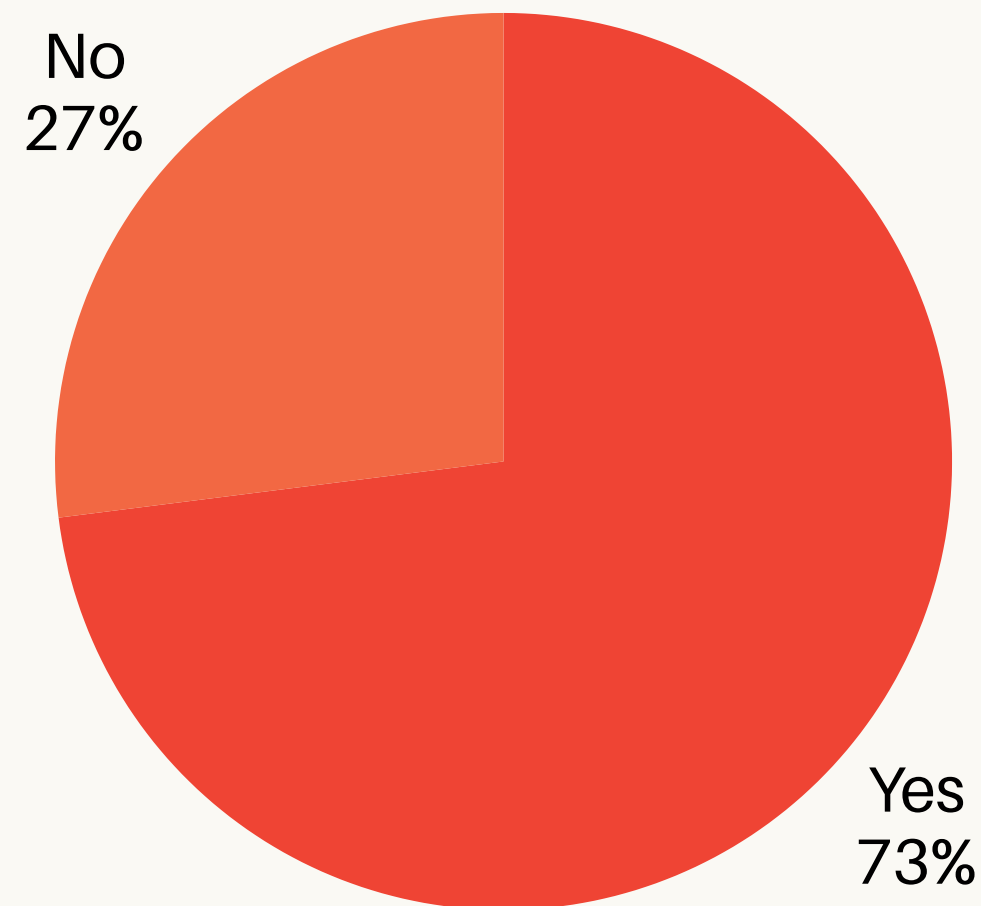
*"I rarely see dandruff on others and I believe daily showering prevents it.
Maybe those with dandruff may not wash often enough, I guess?"*

The stigma comes mostly from those who don't experience dandruff, meaning communication must **educate non-sufferers** as much as sufferers.

DANDRUFF IS NORMAL BUT PERSONAL, THE REAL PAIN POINT IS BEING SEEN WITH FLAKES.

MOST GEN Z HAVE EXPERIENCED DANDRUFF AT SOME POINT.

SURVEY



"Have you experienced dandruff or scalp flaking in the past 6 months"

INTERVIEW

"It's a pretty common problem."

"I feel like a lot of my friends got it too... I think it's just a hormonal thing."

PEOPLE DON'T MIND HAVING IT, BUT MIND OTHERS SEEING IT

"It makes me really insecure about myself... I thought people would judge me."

"I didn't say anything... it was a little bit embarrassing (when salon staff pointed it out)."

"They would say, 'There's something on your hair,' and pull out a white thing... I was embarrassed."

DANDRUFF CARRIES A **QUIET** BUT **PERSISTENT SOCIAL STIGMA**, ESPECIALLY AMONG **WOMEN**.

FEMALE

"Embarrassing if someone sees flakes."

"Feels unhygienic even if I know it's not."

"I hide it and wash hair more when I see flakes."

"Self-conscious wearing dark clothes."

MALE

VS.

"Guys don't care much."

"Women judge dandruff more than men do."

VISUAL FLAKES TRIGGER NEGATIVE ASSUMPTIONS ABOUT HYGIENE.

"I would assume someone with dandruff is not taking care properly."

"I know flakes don't mean dirty, but the stereotype is real."

THE EMOTIONAL TRIGGER IS HOW OTHERS WILL PERCEIVE THEM.

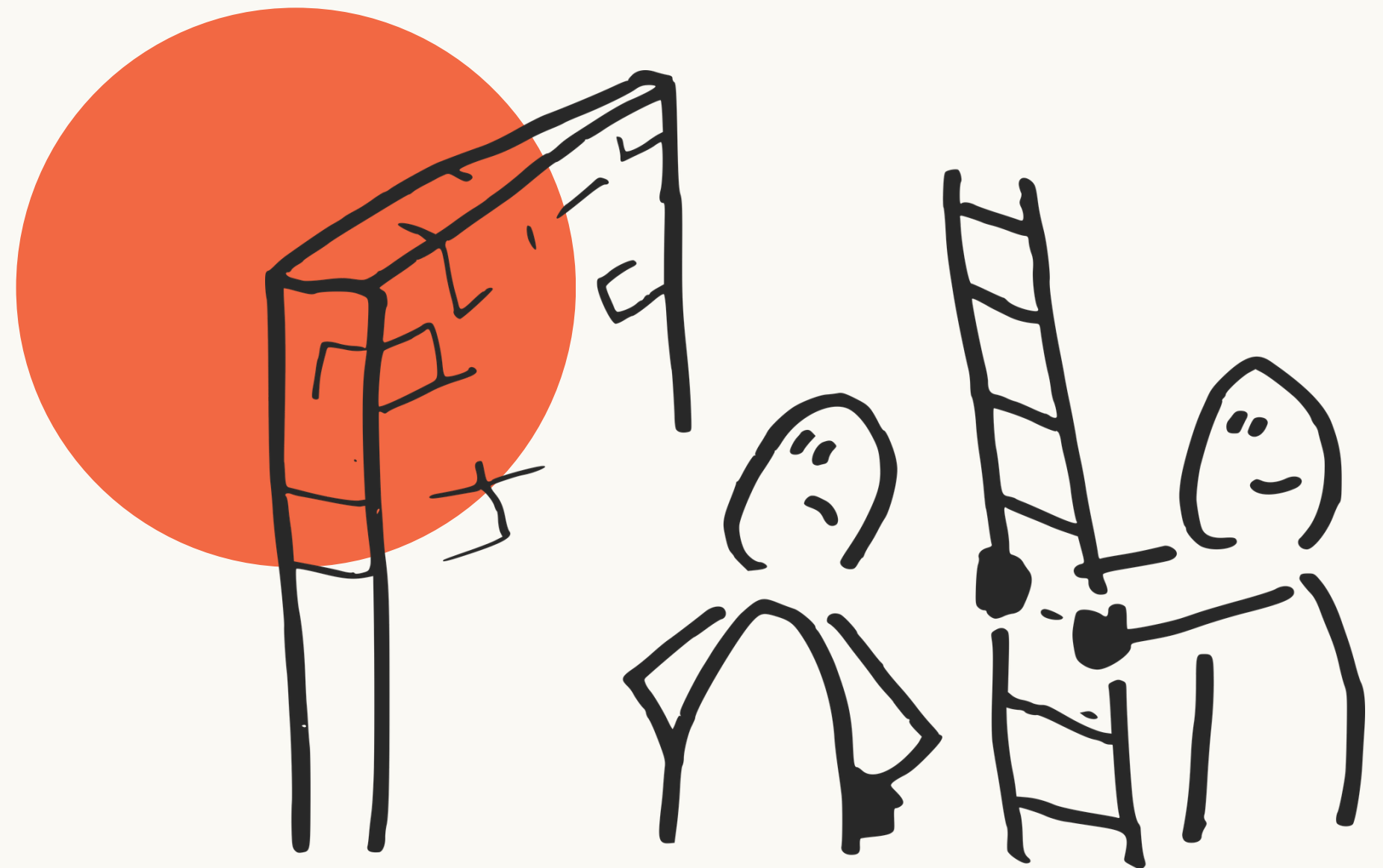
FEMALES APPEAR TO HAVE “LESS DANDRUFF” BECAUSE BEAUTY STANDARDS HIDE IT.

Participants consistently report seeing dandruff **more often on males** than females. Many attribute this to **higher beauty expectations placed on women**, which leads people to assume women “shouldn’t” or “don’t” have visible flakes. This creates a perception that dandruff is a more male issue, even though prevalence is similar across genders.

“

“I think I would probably more likely see it on females because females have a higher standard of beauty... I don't think I would notice it on a guy friend.”

”



AFTER EXPERIENCING DANDRUFF, PEOPLE NOTICE IT MOST ON **SAME-GENDER PEERS**

People who have gone through dandruff themselves become **more attentive** to the issue in others, but they mostly notice it within their **own gender group**. This reflects social proximity: people look more closely at peers of the same gender (classmates, roommates, teammates) and are therefore more likely to detect scalp issues there.

“To be honest, I only notice what my male friends use.”

“If they're really close to me, and I see the flakes, I would ask them if they need help... like my close friends.”

MOTHERS' FAVOURITE AND HOUSEHOLD BRAND

Teenage Years Are the Origin Point of Dandruff Awareness

"Teenage hormonal; most classmates had dandruff"

Mothers Are the Default Advisors & Product Gatekeepers

Female respondents consistently described their **mothers as the primary source** of guidance for treating dandruff, often before social media, friends, or personal research. Moms are also the **household shampoo decision-makers**, controlling what products get purchased.

"Mom noticed first."

"Didn't know what dandruff was until parent pointed it out."

Head & Shoulders = A "Teenage Household Shampoo"

Because mothers tend to default to familiar, trusted brands, Head & Shoulders frequently becomes Gen Z's first anti-dandruff product. They associate H&S with **family bathrooms, growing up, and parent-chosen routines**, not something they chose for themselves.

"It's what my parents bought growing up."

*"It's the typical product that you use growing up.
Something you used in middle school or high school."*

SALON RECOMMENDATIONS REINFORCE THIS EARLY STAGE



A few respondents also received anti-dandruff recommendations from salons, further anchoring that the first line of defense usually comes from authority figures, not from peers or influencers.

“The salon guy recommended this natural anti-dandruff shampoo.”

“The hairdresser told me to switch to a gentler anti-dandruff shampoo because my scalp was irritated.”

WHEN AUTONOMY ARRIVES, BEAUTY TAKES OVER: GEN Z WOMEN SHIFT TOWARD “MORE ME” BRANDS

As female Gen Z consumers gain independence in their late teens, they naturally move away from Head & Shoulders. Once they control their own purchases (age ~17–21), they gravitate toward shampoos that feel more aesthetic, more moisturizing, and more aligned with femininity and self-expression. While H&S remains respected for practicality and effectiveness, it no longer fits the beauty-driven identity they want in their daily routine. For many, H&S becomes a “childhood” or “family” brand, useful, but not personal, beautiful, or expressive enough as they mature.

“I prefer something that’s more gentle to my hair.”

“Head & Shoulders is more for dandruff... it’s not something I would choose for daily beauty.

“It feels more clinical... not premium.”

HEAD & SHOULDERS IDENTITY IS STUCK IN FUNCTIONAL, MASCULINE, INEXPENSIVE TERRITORY, FAR FROM GEN Z'S BEAUTY STANDARDS.

QUALITATIVE

"Packaging is too masculine." "Feels like a cheap brand." "Look like something my dad would buy."

Please rate how you perceive Head & Shoulders on the following scales. Standard Deviation

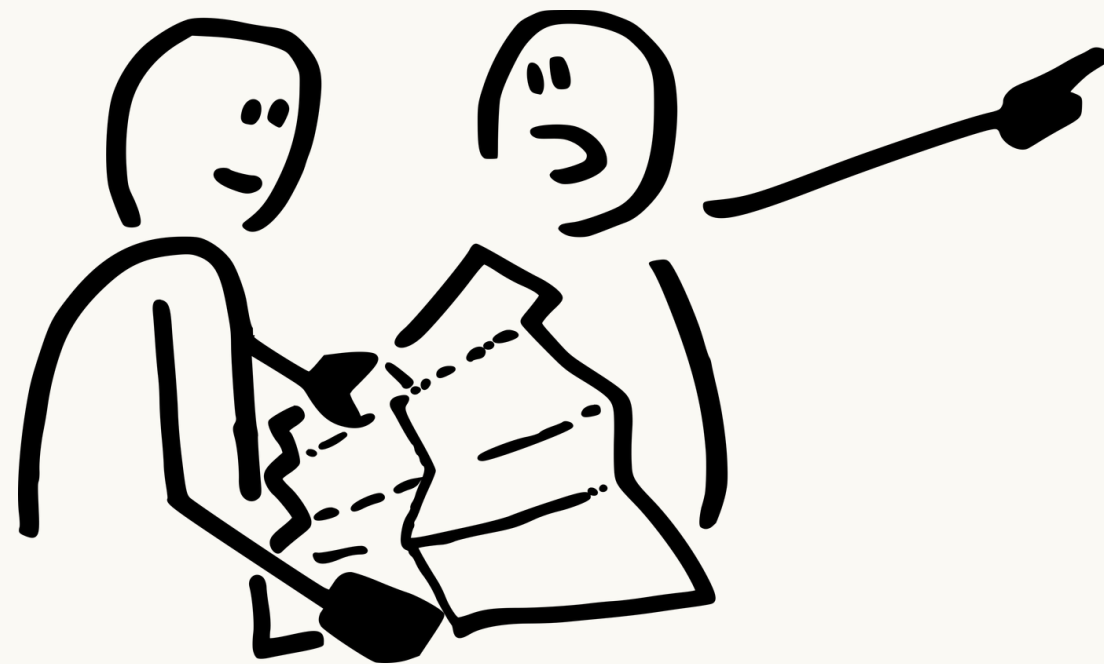
SURVEY

Harsh:Gentle	0.92
Ineffective:Effective	1.13
Clinical:Self-care oriented	1.14
Old-fashioned:Modern	1.11
Masculine:Feminine	0.83
Basic:Premium	0.87
Embarrassing to be seen using:Proud to be seen using	0.77

BOTH GENDERS SEE FEMALE H&S USERS AS LESS INVESTED IN HAIRCARE

Both males and females view **females using H&S as not caring much about their hair** (in a somewhat neutral, leaning to negative direction), because they perceive Head & Shoulders as an accessible, affordable supermarket brand and one that is **not elevated enough** for female audiences.

"Out of the ones that I know what hair products they use, I don't think any of [my female friends] use Head & Shoulders. If I see a girl using it, I would be a little surprised... it feels like a male brand."



"What kind of person uses Head & Shoulders? Probably... a college man... I don't think women use Head & Shoulders very much in my imagination."

"My mom would never use Head & Shoulders... she would be offended if you gave her H&S"

BUYING A NEW SHAMPOO IS A COMMITMENT

Almost everyone agrees that buying a new brand of shampoo is a **significant commitment**, as they can't switch until they finish their current bottle, unless the product is extremely bad.



"Normally I will wait until I finish this kind of hair product to try a new one."

"It was so terrible to the point that I had to change the product right away... but normally I will wait until I finish it."

"I have a really big bottle of it... so I'm still using it even though I don't like it that much."

BUT GEN Z WANTS TO **EXPLORE** AND TRY NEW BRANDS ONCE THE BOTTLE IS DONE.

However, it shows that both female and male Gen Z consumers want to **explore different ones** (brands, product lines, etc.) after they finish their bottles.



"I want to explore a little bit... I'm an exploratory person, so I just go around and try new ones."

"I'm down to trying new shampoo because I switched many different types recently, because I really want to know which shampoo works best for my hair."

"Yeah, I would try any product to test it out... I would love to try it out if it is well known... or has some kind of formula that can tackle this kind of problem."

BORROWING SHAMPOO AT OTHERS' HOMES ACTS AS AN INFORMAL TRIAL MECHANISM

Female consumers vividly recall experiences using shampoos at relatives' homes, boyfriends' places, or while traveling, these moments shape brand perceptions and can spark future switching.

"It's not because I intentionally tried it. I had no other options, so I tried it."

"I never bought Head & Shoulder, but I feel like I might have used it from the people around me. Maybe I have used it from my ex..."

"...if I go to my grandparents' house, I would have to use their shampoo... it might have been Head & Shoulders."

"I'm sure I've used it, like traveling or in a hotel, or like... at another friend's house or something... I'm sure I have."



IMPLICATIONS/RECOMMENDATIONS

BRANDING COMMUNICATION

1, COMMUNICATION DIFFERENTLY FOR MALE AND FEMALE AUDIENCES

Insight: Dandruff awareness is gendered. People notice flakes mainly within their own gender group.

Implication: A singular, unisex message lacks precision. The brand needs:

- male-specific social contexts (locker room, barber shop, teams)
- female-specific emotional contexts (beauty routine, embarrassment, self-image)

2, H&S MUST SOFTEN ITS MEDICAL IMAGE FOR WOMEN WHILE RETAINING EFFICACY FOR MEN.

Insight: Dandruff is seen as more noticeable in men because women “shouldn’t have it.”

Implication: There is a beauty standard gap, where dandruff on women violates expectations and feels more shameful. Female consumers need:

- empathy in messaging
- beauty-forward reassurance (“you’re still put together, even when treating scalp issues”)
- visually aesthetic packaging that fits their bathroom aesthetic

H&S must soften its medical image for women while retaining efficacy for men.

IMPLICATIONS/RECOMMENDATIONS

BRANDING COMMUNICATION

3, POSITION ITSELF AS THE CONFIDENCE RESTORER, NOT THE “DANDRUFF BRAND.”

Insight: Dandruff treatment is not stigmatized, dandruff visibility is.

Implication: People are embarrassed about flakes, but not embarrassed about using H&S. Shift comms from:
“You have dandruff → use H&S” to “You deserve to feel confident → here’s the fastest way back”

4, SIMPLE EDUCATION, NOT MEDICAL/SCIENTIFIC EDUCATION.

Insight: Dandruff is widely misunderstood (oil, dry scalp, poor hygiene).

Implication: Education is needed, but not medical/scientific education.

- Consumers respond better to: simple explanations, metaphors, visually intuitive cues.
- Efficacy messaging must be: simple and visual

IMPLICATIONS/RECOMMENDATIONS

CREATE A BEAUTY-FORWARD LINE

Insight: Female consumers feel H&S is “not feminine,” “not beautiful,” “not elevated.”

Reasons: Even with its current female line,

- Packaging seen as masculine or clinical
- No brand story or beauty heritage
- Positioned as cheap, functional, supermarket-level
- Doesn't fit the curated bathroom aesthetic women care about

Implication: H&S must create a beauty-forward line (visuals, scent, positioning) to regain relevance among women.



IMPLICATIONS/RECOMMENDATIONS

LOW-RISK TRIAL FORMATS

Insight: Shampoo switching is infrequent because bottles last long, trial is expensive.

Gen Z wants to explore, but is locked in by bottle size and cost. Trial moments often come from:

- friend's place
- relatives' home
- partner's home
- hotel's shampoo
- small/one-off usage at a salon

Implication: H&S must create low-risk trial formats: minis, travel-size sets, "starter kits", salon try-before-buy programs

This makes switching frictionless.

MARKETING STRATEGY

BRAND OBJECTIVE

Reclaim relevance among Gen Z by repositioning H&S from a “functional, parent-bought shampoo” to a beauty-forward, confidence-building scalp-care brand.

TARGET STRATEGY

Gen Z Female “The Beauty Seeker”

Needs:

- aesthetic products
- gentle, pretty, clean-girl vibes
- no embarrassment
- strong stigma barrier

Barrier: H&S feels masculine, clinical, cheap

Opportunity: create beauty-forward line + emotional messaging

Gen Z Male “The Quick Fixer”

Needs:

- fast clean
- oil control
- convenience
- social proof

Barrier: uses H&S only if parents bought it

Opportunity: reclaim male authority via barbers, sports, grooming

BRAND POSITIONING

“Head & Shoulders restores confidence by caring for your scalp the way great beauty brands care for your hair.”

- New emotional territory: confidence
- New functional territory: scalp care
- New visual territory: science + beauty

MARKETING STRATEGY

NEW PRODUCT LINE

H&S SOFT & PURE

pastel bottles, gentle scent profiles, hydrating formulas,
“aesthetic enough for your bathroom”

H&S ACTIVE CLEAN FOR MEN

deep clean, cooling sensation, masculine
packaging, barber-endorsed

Gen Z Female “The Beauty Seeker”

Tone: soft, warm, aesthetic, relatable

Content ideas:

- “Moments of self-consciousness” → fixing it → “back to me again”
- “Your scalp is skin too”
- Bathroom shelfie aesthetics
- “Beautiful hair starts at the root”

Gen Z Male “The Quick Fixer”

Tone: straightforward, humorous, confident

Content ideas:

- Barber POV (“bro, you got flakes—here’s what works”)
- Locker-room talk
- TikTok “scalp check challenge”
- Oil control + refresh moments

COMMUNICATION STRATEGY

MARKETING STRATEGY

NEW PRODUCT LINE

SOCIAL STRATEGY

TikTok

- Day-in-my-life influencers
- Scalp-check trend
- “I used this for 7 days” real results
- Beauty creators explaining scalp skin

Instagram

- Aesthetic posts for female line
- Clean bathroom shots
- Dermatologist reels

YouTube

- Longer explainer videos
- Scalp science
- Testimonials
- “Confidence reset” narrative ads

RETAIL STRATEGY

Offline

- Target, Walmart, CVS: split gender sections
- Display testers and minis
- Beauty-endcap for female line

Salons

- “Free scalp cleanse with H&S demo”
- Sell trial kits at checkout

Gyms & Dorms

- Partnerships for vending machine sachets

SUCCESS METRICS

- Increase female purchase intent by +25%
- Increase trial conversions via minis by +40%
- Reduce perception of H&S as “male brand” by 20%
- Increase “beauty relevance” rating among Gen Z women
- Retail sell-through improvement for trial sizes